

Designing Assessments in an AI-Influenced World

Artificial intelligence changes how easily polished work can be produced, but it does not change what matters most in learning. This framework is designed to help educators make deliberate, transparent assessment decisions in a world where AI is present, accessible, and evolving. This is not a compliance tool. It is a design-thinking resource.

The goal is to support clarity, fairness, and the protection of meaningful student learning by focusing first on purpose and evidence, and only then on the role AI may play.

A Core Design Principle

Before deciding whether AI is allowed, limited, or excluded, we must first be clear about:

- Why the assessment exists
- What evidence of learning actually matters
- What thinking must remain visible and human

When these decisions are explicit, AI expectations become clearer, more equitable, and easier to communicate.

What This Framework Assumes

This framework is built on several shared assumptions:

- AI will be present in students' learning environments, whether directly or indirectly.
- Durable learning is learning that requires reasoning, judgment, transfer, or decision-making.
- Vulnerable learning is learning that can be completed convincingly through automation with minimal understanding.
- Assessment design, not tool access, determines whether learning is protected or undermined.

What the Chart Is Designed to Do

The chart that follows is designed to help educators:

- Clarify the primary purpose of an assessment
- Identify which types of evidence best serve that purpose

- Anticipate where learning may be durable or vulnerable when AI is present
- Design assessments where AI can support learning without replacing it

Each example in the chart intentionally includes AI to model how assessments can be designed with AI in mind, rather than treated as an afterthought.

The chart is not:

- A list of approved or prohibited AI uses
- A scoring rubric for evaluating teachers
- A one-size-fits-all solution
- A replacement for professional judgment

Instead, it is a conversation tool that helps educators reason through tradeoffs and align design decisions.

How to Read the Chart

- Read across a row to see how different evidence choices affect durability for the same purpose.
- Read down a column to see how the same type of evidence functions differently depending on purpose.
- Notice that no evidence type is always durable or always vulnerable.
Durability depends on how evidence is used and what thinking it reveals.

As you read, keep this question in mind: ***If AI were used here, would the most important student thinking still be visible?***

Shared Language Used in This Framework

The chart that follows relies on specific language to describe assessment purposes, types of evidence, and learning durability. The definitions below establish a shared understanding of how these terms are used in this framework.

These are working definitions, intended to support clear assessment design conversations rather than prescribe universal rules.

Assessment Purposes

Assessment Purpose	Description
Demonstrate Understanding	Assessments designed to determine whether students understand key concepts, skills, or ideas. The focus is on making thinking visible, not just identifying correct answers.
Show Reasoning or Judgment	Assessments designed to surface how students make decisions, evaluate options, and justify choices. Emphasis is placed on why a student chose an approach.
Apply Learning in a New Context	Assessments designed to examine whether students can transfer learning beyond familiar examples or procedures into novel or less-structured situations.
Practice With Feedback	Assessments designed to support learning in progress. Evidence informs feedback, revision, and growth rather than final evaluation.
Communicate Ideas to an Audience	Assessments designed to evaluate how well students tailor ideas for a specific audience, purpose, or medium, including clarity, tone, and intent.
Explore Ideas or Possibilities	Assessments designed to encourage curiosity, experimentation, and divergent thinking. Value is placed on exploration and sense-making rather than precision.
Build Metacognition and Self-Regulation	Assessments designed to help students plan, monitor, evaluate, and adjust their own learning strategies and processes.
Develop Learning Habits and Dispositions	Assessments designed to support habits such as persistence, collaboration, ethical decision-making, and responsible tool use over time.
Check Readiness or Progress Over Time	Assessments designed to track growth, trends, or readiness rather than mastery at a single point in time.
Inform Instructional or System Decisions	Assessments designed to help educators make decisions about instruction, supports, curriculum, or pacing. These are not evaluative of individual students.

Types of Evidence

Type of Evidence	Description
Process Evidence	Evidence that shows how students work through learning, including drafts, annotations, planning notes, steps, attempts, or iterations. Makes thinking visible over time.
Reasoning Evidence	Evidence that captures why students make particular choices, including explanations, justifications, tradeoffs, oral thinking, or written rationale.
Product Evidence	Evidence of the final artifact, performance, or response a student produces. Shows outcomes, but not necessarily thinking.
Reflection Evidence	Evidence that captures how students think about their own learning, including what changed, why it changed, what was learned, or what questions remain.

Learning Durability Language

Term	Description
Durable Learning	Learning that remains meaningful when AI is present because it requires reasoning, judgment, transfer, decision-making, or explanation that cannot be automated without loss of understanding.
Vulnerable Learning	Learning that can be completed convincingly through automation with minimal understanding, often when evidence relies heavily on correctness, polish, or final products alone.
Context-Dependent	Evidence that can be durable or vulnerable depending on how it is designed, supported, and paired with other forms of evidence.

The chart that follows brings these assessment purposes, evidence types, and durability concepts together to support intentional assessment design when AI is present.

Assessment Purpose	Process Evidence	Reasoning Evidence	Product Evidence	Reflection Evidence
Demonstrate Understanding	Durable when students use AI to generate an explanation, then annotate where it matches or conflicts with their understanding. <i>Example:</i> Student highlights parts of an AI explanation they agree or disagree with and explains why.	Durable because students must explain concepts in their own words, even if AI was used for clarification. <i>Example:</i> Student orally explains a concept after checking AI for misconceptions.	Vulnerable if AI-generated correct answers are submitted without explanation. <i>Example:</i> AI-written response turned in as-is.	Context-Dependent when students reflect on what AI helped clarify or confuse. <i>Example:</i> Exit slip naming one thing AI helped with and one thing they verified.
Show Reasoning or Judgment	Durable when students use AI to compare strategies, then document which they chose and why. <i>Example:</i> Student asks AI for two solution paths and justifies their choice.	Highly Durable because students must defend decisions AI cannot make for them. <i>Example:</i> Student explains why they rejected an AI-suggested approach.	Context-Dependent when paired with justification. <i>Example:</i> Final solution with a written rationale describing AI's role.	Durable when students reflect on decision-making, not output. <i>Example:</i> Student explains how AI influenced but did not determine choices.

Apply Learning in a New Context	Durable when students use AI to brainstorm applications, then plan how learning transfers. <i>Example:</i> Student documents how they adapted an AI suggestion to a new context.	Durable when students explain how prior learning was transferred despite AI assistance. <i>Example:</i> Student explains why some AI suggestions did not fit the new context.	Context-Dependent depending on novelty. <i>Example:</i> Application product created with AI support but paired with explanation.	Durable when students reflect on limits of AI transfer. <i>Example:</i> Student explains what AI could not account for in the situation.
Practice With Feedback	Durable when students use AI feedback across drafts and track revisions. <i>Example:</i> Student documents changes made after AI feedback and teacher feedback.	Durable when students explain which AI feedback they accepted or rejected. <i>Example:</i> Student explains why they ignored certain AI suggestions.	Vulnerable if only the final AI-polished product is assessed. <i>Example:</i> Final draft submitted without revision history.	Durable when students reflect on growth and learning strategies. <i>Example:</i> Student reflects on how feedback improved thinking.
Communicate Ideas to an Audience	Context-Dependent when AI supports planning but students justify choices. <i>Example:</i> Student uses AI to outline a presentation, then explains audience decisions.	Durable when students explain tone, structure, and message choices. <i>Example:</i> Student explains why they revised AI-generated language for clarity.	Vulnerable if AI-generated polish replaces message clarity. <i>Example:</i> Highly polished AI slides with minimal original insight.	Durable when students assess communication effectiveness. <i>Example:</i> Student reflects on audience feedback vs. AI suggestions.

Explore Ideas or Possibilities	Durable when students use AI to generate ideas and document experimentation paths. <i>Example:</i> Student records multiple AI-generated ideas and why some were abandoned.	Durable when students explain risks and creative decisions. <i>Example:</i> Student explains why they pursued one AI-suggested idea over others.	Context-Dependent when novelty matters more than accuracy. <i>Example:</i> Prototype created with AI as a brainstorming partner.	Durable when students reflect on discoveries and open questions. <i>Example:</i> Student reflects on how AI expanded or narrowed thinking.
Build Metacognition and Self-Regulation	Durable when students plan learning using AI and monitor progress. <i>Example:</i> Student uses AI to suggest study strategies, then tracks effectiveness.	Durable when students explain strategy choices. <i>Example:</i> Student explains why an AI-suggested strategy did or did not work.	Vulnerable if reduced to AI-generated checklists. <i>Example:</i> AI study plan followed without reflection.	Highly Durable when students reflect on learning habits. <i>Example:</i> Student reflects on how AI affected focus and effort.
Develop Learning Habits and Dispositions	Durable when students document collaboration or ethical decisions with AI present. <i>Example:</i> Student notes how AI use was negotiated in group work.	Durable when students explain ethical or collaborative choices. <i>Example:</i> Student explains when AI use felt appropriate or inappropriate.	Vulnerable if habits are inferred from AI-polished products. <i>Example:</i> Group project graded only on final output.	Durable when students reflect on responsibility and impact. <i>Example:</i> Student reflects on how AI affected collaboration.
Check Readiness or Progress Over Time	Context-Dependent when AI supports tracking but students interpret results. <i>Example:</i> Student uses AI to graph progress and explain trends.	Durable when students analyze their own data. <i>Example:</i> Student explains growth patterns using AI summaries.	Vulnerable if AI-generated scores are accepted without interpretation. <i>Example:</i> Benchmark score reviewed without analysis.	Durable when students set goals based on interpreted data. <i>Example:</i> Student reflects on next steps after reviewing AI-generated trends.

Inform Instructional or System Decisions	Durable when educators use AI to identify patterns across student work. <i>Example:</i> Teacher uses AI to analyze exit slips for trends.	Context-Dependent when reasoning is collective. <i>Example:</i> Team discusses AI-identified misconceptions.	Vulnerable if AI summaries replace professional judgment. <i>Example:</i> Curriculum decisions made from AI summaries alone.	Durable when educators reflect on instructional impact. <i>Example:</i> Team reflects on what AI surfaced and what it missed.
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